Lesson 44: Editing and Grammar Review

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 20 Editing / Grammar Review.

In this lesson

This is the last lesson of Stage 2. You review the editing skills of the course by correcting real sentences from student writing. Then you write a five-paragraph essay and edit it one error type at a time, the way good academic writers check their work.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Find and correct errors in sentence structure, punctuation, verbs, nouns, pronouns, word forms and word order.
- Correct sentences with several types of errors, and know which types you make most often.
- Plan, write and edit a five-paragraph essay.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
fragment	an incomplete sentence (no subject, no verb, or only a dependent clause)	Is rich in vitamin C.
run-on sentence	two sentences joined with no punctuation or connecting word	Many of us went through many experiences some of them are interesting.
comma splice	two sentences joined only with a comma	I will see her in a few weeks, she will come to Chicago.
dependent clause	a clause (subject + verb) that cannot stand alone, for example after "when, because, although"	Whenever a storm comes, ...
subject-verb agreement	a singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb	Nobody **has** enough time.
noncount noun	a noun with no plural form	advice, homework, information
noun-pronoun agreement	a pronoun matches its noun in number and gender	my friends forced me to take **them** (those rides)
word form	the form of a word for each part of speech: noun, verb, adjective, adverb	kind, kindly

Rules and explanations

The sentences are not connected; they show typical mistakes in student writing. Notice which ones you also make. The best way to improve is to write and then edit your own writing.

What to check (and where you studied it)

Area	Check for	Wrong → right
Sentence structure and punctuation (Lessons 13, 14, 18)	fragments, run-ons, comma splices; a comma after a dependent clause at the start; a comma before "and, but, so" joining two sentences; "; however," between sentences	Whenever, a storm comes, I remember ... → Whenever a storm comes, I remember ...
Verbs (Lessons 5, 17, 24, 26, 29, 34, 37)	subject-verb agreement; the right tense; "be" before adjectives such as "afraid, late, bored"; modal + base verb	Everyone should has a textbook. → ... should have ...
Nouns (Lesson 39)	plural -s; no -s on noncount nouns; a determiner before a singular count noun; "one of" + plural noun	I waited ten minute. → ... ten minutes.
Pronouns (Lesson 40)	agreement; no extra pronoun after the subject; "my cousins and I"; clear reference; it's / its	I and my cousins played. → My cousins and I played.
Word forms (Lesson 41)	the right part of speech; -ed (feeling) / -ing (cause); -er / more, the -est / the most	He treated us kind. → ... kindly.
Word order (Lesson 42)	adjectives before the noun and in order; frequency words; embedded questions (question word + subject + verb)	Our family every year goes ... → Every year, our family goes ...

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic often joins many sentences with "and" or commas. In English, a comma alone cannot join two sentences: use a period, a semicolon, or a connecting word such as "because", "so" or "but".
> - Arabic present-tense sentences can have no verb "be". English needs it: "People like cats because they **are** quieter than dogs."

Practice

Correct the error(s) in each sentence. There may be more than one error in a sentence.

A. Sentence structure and punctuation

1. I have a lot of writing homework, also I have tons of reading homework.
2. When I saw the horse I was surprised and happy.
3. The fish is very beautiful but it's hard to feed.
4. I go to class on time, and finish my homework on time.
5. Dogs are helpful, they can help blind people on the street.

6. Even though, it was hard to get my visa I got it after two months.
7. My wife does not like sports, nor she likes gardening.
8. Everybody enjoyed the game because of the weather was so nice.
9. I love this boy he gives me power in my life.
10. My mom the most important member of my family.

B. Verbs

1. The teacher do not wanted to put much pressure on his students.
2. My younger son had sick.
3. There is a lot of benefits of having a car in the U.S.
4. Doing exercises help us have a healthier life.
5. Most of the customers is fine and friendly.
6. I have never studies psychology in my life.
7. The dress maybe mine.
8. Since that day, I going to Mariano's regularly.
9. Twelve people have died in the shooting last weekend.
10. If you late, you will miss part of the lesson.

C. Nouns

1. When I was a child, I enjoyed three thing.
2. Every kids wanted to win this competition.
3. I remember my parents' advices.
4. They fed some chickens, gooses, cows, and planted different vegetable on the farm.
5. It was one of the happiest day of my life.
6. A travel agents learn about each airports.
7. Many woman has a large family and a lot of houseworks.
8. They have an eight-years-old son.
9. I had chickens for dinner yesterday.
10. I must wear my glass when I drive at night.

D. Pronouns

1. Every country has their own beauty.
2. Each student should bring their own book.
3. Cats are better pets than dogs because it is very clean.
4. Me and my friend, we came back to our home after shopping.
5. Old people are not able to take care them self.
6. We were enjoying and continued singing songs.
7. In class, some classmates tried to talk with me, but I did not give him a response.

8. I was very excited about the gifts, but my mother did not allow me to open it.
9. All my friends and cousins we ate the leftover cake.
10. This experience has taught me that you must be more careful and prepared when you travel to a foreign country.

E. Word forms

1. Playing in a musical group was very excited to him.
2. Adopting a cat is easy than adopting a dog.
3. Cats are more smaller than dogs.
4. She is beautiful and middle age.
5. Her jokes make her students laugh, so they do not feel boring.
6. When I saw the horse, I was surprise and happy.
7. My mother and grandmother have a deeply regret.
8. The interview started good.
9. People judge others very fast and easy.
10. Studying English will be very benefit to my career.

F. Word order

1. She is a person very energetic.
2. The teacher always is smiling and trying to learn something about the students.
3. I every afternoon do my homework.
4. He comes frequently late to class.
5. Always the tutors are very helpful.
6. Our math teacher was a young tall man, about 25 years old.
7. He was driving a Chrysler new pickup truck.
8. When my son is hungry, he eats a meal very big.
9. On the first day of class, we did not know where was the classroom, so we went to the ESL office to ask how could we find it.
10. Could you tell us what time is it?

G. Mixed editing (errors of any type)

1. I love my son very much, he is my older son, he is twenty years old.
2. When she say something, people wants to listen her.
3. People in my native country is expert in making clothes and jewelries.
4. The man chased us, and he said that "why do you take my daughter?"
5. On that day I decided, I will never be scared. However if I ever got scared, then I will start praying.
6. When I wake up in the morning, always I feel so refreshed and good. Usually in the morning, I go running outside, I run for thirty minutes.

7. One day, when my cousin go to buy the things she need for dinner, she park in the wrong place because she not saw the yellow lines.
8. My parents pass away, and I make a decision to bring my brother and sister to U.S. because we didn't have any opportunities in our country.
9. I want to work independently by myself. Therefore, I choose interior design for my profession. I eventually went to a school, and I got a license. Now I enjoy my career.
10. Sisters help to cope with everyday problems and to reduce stress, promoting happiness, and optimism.

More items: lesson material, sections II to VIII. Your tutor can check them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to the combining exercise and the other sentences in sections II to VIII of the lesson material."
- "Here is my essay: [paste]. Do not correct it. Mark each error with a code: S (sentence structure), V (verb), N (noun), P (pronoun), WF (word form), WO (word order). Then check my corrections."
- "Which two error types do I make most often? Give me ten new sentences with those errors to correct."

Writing task

Your final task brings together the paragraph and essay skills of Stage 2.

1. Choose an enumerative or narrative paragraph that you wrote in this course, or an essay topic from Lesson 43.
2. Expand it into a five-paragraph essay of 400 to 600 words: a title; an introductory paragraph with a hook and a thesis statement; three supporting paragraphs, each with a topic sentence, details and a transition; and a concluding paragraph.
3. Edit the essay in six rounds, one area at a time (see "What to check" above).
4. Keep an error log: the error, its type and the correction.

Self-editing checklist:

- The thesis statement ends the introduction; each supporting paragraph starts with a topic sentence.
- Transitions connect the supporting paragraphs; the conclusion has no new topic.
- No fragments, run-ons or comma splices.
- Verbs agree with their subjects; tenses are correct and consistent.
- Nouns and pronouns: plurals, noncount nouns, determiners, agreement.
- Word forms and word order: parts of speech, -ed / -ing, comparisons, adjectives, frequency words, embedded questions.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Other correct versions are sometimes possible, especially in G; ask your tutor about yours.

A.

1. ... homework. Also, I have ... (or: ... homework; also, I have ...)
2. When I saw the horse, I was ... (book: the same sentence is in the combining exercise)
3. ... beautiful, but it's hard to feed.
4. I go to class on time and finish ... (one subject with two verbs: no comma)
5. Dogs are helpful because they can ... (or: helpful. They can ... / helpful; they can ...)
6. Even though it was hard to get my visa, I got it ...
7. ... nor does she like gardening.
8. ... because the weather was so nice. (or: because of the nice weather)
9. I love this boy because he gives ... (or: I love this boy. He gives ...)
10. My mom is the most important ...

B.

1. The teacher did not want (or: does not want) to put ...
2. My younger son was sick.
3. There are a lot of benefits ...
4. Doing exercises helps us ... (a gerund subject is singular)
5. Most of the customers are fine and friendly.
6. I have never studied psychology ...
7. The dress may be mine. ("maybe" is an adverb; "may be" is modal + verb)
8. Since that day, I have been going (or: I have gone) to Mariano's regularly.
9. Twelve people died in the shooting last weekend. ("last weekend" is finished past time)
10. If you are late, ...

C.

1. three things 2. Every kid 3. my parents' advice 4. geese; different vegetables 5. the happiest days 6. A travel agent learns about each airport. 7. Many women have a large family (or: large families) and a lot of housework. 8. an eight-year-old son 9. I had chicken for dinner (chicken as food is noncount). 10. my glasses

D.

1. Every country has its own beauty.
2. ... his or her own book. (Or: All students should bring their own books. APA style also accepts "their".)
3. ... because they are very clean.

4. My friend and I came back ...
5. ... take care of themselves.
6. We were enjoying ourselves ...
7. ... give them a response.
8. ... to open them.
9. All my friends and cousins ate ...
10. ... taught me that I must be more careful and prepared when I travel ...

E.

1. very exciting 2. easier than 3. smaller (no "more") 4. middle-aged 5. bored 6. surprised 7. a deep regret 8. started well 9. fast and easily 10. very beneficial

F.

1. She is a very energetic person.
2. The teacher is always smiling ...
3. I do my homework every afternoon. (Or: Every afternoon, I do my homework.)
4. He frequently comes late to class. (Or: Frequently, he comes late to class. / He comes late to class frequently.)
5. The tutors are always very helpful.
6. a tall young man (size before age)
7. a new Chrysler pickup truck (age before origin)
8. he eats a very big meal.
9. ... we did not know where the classroom was, so we went to the ESL office to ask how we could find it.
10. Could you tell us what time it is?

G.

1. I love my son very much. He is my older son, and he is twenty years old.
2. When she says something, people want to listen to her.
3. People in my native country are experts in making clothes and jewelry.
4. The man chased us and asked, "Why are you taking (or: did you take) my daughter?" (Or: ... and asked why we were taking his daughter.)
5. On that day, I decided that I would never be scared. However, if I ever got scared, (then) I would start praying.
6. ... I always feel so refreshed and good. Usually in the morning, I go running outside, and I run for thirty minutes.
7. went ... needed ... parked ... did not see
8. passed away ... made ... to the U.S. (The rest is correct.)

9. I wanted to work independently ("by myself" means the same, so delete it). Therefore, I chose interior design as my profession. (The rest is correct.)
10. Sisters help (us) cope with everyday problems, reduce stress, and promote happiness and optimism. (Or: help to cope …, to reduce …, and to promote …. The three verbs need the same form, and there is no comma before "and optimism".)

My notes